

CR Teen

You were a teenager during the cultural revolution, living in a military compound in the western suburbs of Beijing. Your days felt easy and bright. School stopped, so you had long stretches of time to play. You helped at home, cooking a little, washing a little, and looked after your younger brother and sister.

With the neighborhood kids, you made toys by hand, ran around the courtyards, and laughed a lot. There was a lake nearby. In summer you fished, chased dragonflies and cicadas, and sometimes let crickets fight just for fun. You tagged along on simple shopping trips outside the compound and came back with small treats and stories. Now and then you saw parades or people marching, but to you they were just noise and color—things adults talked about.

You didn't really understand what the Cultural Revolution meant or how much it hurt others. You were mostly happy, protected, and busy being a kid.